

No Child's PLAY

With juvenile crime growing alarmingly, it's time to scrutinise social norms and rework the law

| By Swati Mathur |

Ameera Bano is a desperate mother trying to save her 14-year-old son, Riyaz, from the brink of delinquency. He has been smoking weed, stealing money and was recently involved in a bloody brawl with local goons. Exasperated, she has turned to the Children's Observation Centre in downtown Mumbai to take Riyaz under their wing. "Please keep him here for at least one day," she pleads with the superintendent of the centre.

Bano epitomises hundreds of parents across India who are battling juvenile delinquency. Often it's their helplessness to deal with such behaviour that leads the child into the dark world of crime. In many pockets of urban India, childhood has lost its innocence as easy access to money, alcohol and even drugs is pushing teens towards crimes like rape and murder. No wonder that juvenile crimes are on the rise. Two years ago, 22,865 such offences were recorded—a rise of 8.4 per cent over 21,088 cases of the previous year. In Maharashtra alone, the police arrested nearly 6,000 minors—both boys and girls—in connection with murder, robbery, rape, theft, and assault. Last year, nearly 30 per cent of the total crimes in Pune were committed by minors.

Be it the heirs of high-profile business magnates, daughters of single parents or even products of middle-class families, acts of impulse are rampant. In May this year, two Patna-based teenagers, inspired by a Hindi

film, kidnapped and murdered their nine-year-old neighbour. In another gory instance, a five-year-old nursery student in Delhi was allegedly raped by a minor.

What is most alarming is that such tendencies begin to develop in children when they are merely 11. By definition, a delinquent child is one who fails to follow the law or fulfil his duty and the failure is minor in nature. Minors who commit petty crimes are, therefore, referred to as juvenile delinquents. In most cases, delinquency in children starts with them showing scant regard for propriety. "Very often, children observe parents closely when they pay bribes to the police for getting off the hook after committing a traffic offence. Or they find the parents defending them for their mischief in school. The children realise that there is a way to work their way around the law," says Harish Shetty, a Mumbai-based psychiatrist who has worked extensively with delinquent children.

Frustration and distress also make children aggressive. For instance, Mumbai's Sujee Sarkar, 14, murdered Parth Panchal, nine, over a tiff during a football match and hid the body in his cupboard for two days. According to investigating officials, Sarkar was suffering from depression because he discovered that he had been adopted. On the other hand, many children resort to offensive acts to be cool and win acceptance among peer groups. "Whether it is petty theft of cash from their father's wallet to buy beer or killing pavement dwellers



Young and Deadly

Juvenile delinquency is not limited by social strata or geographical location

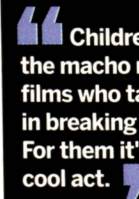
■ May 2009: Two teenagers in Patna abduct and kill a nine-year-old boy for Rs 50 lakh ransom.

■ May 2009: Chandigarh Police arrested 17-year-old for raping and making an



“If children indulge in deliberate criminal acts, they should be tried under the IPC.”

UJJWAL NIKAM,
Special Public Prosecutor



“Children ape the macho man in films who takes pride in breaking laws. For them it's just a cool act.”

SHYAMA CHONA,
Principal, DPS RK Puram

